Will this not hold back India's growth, poverty reduction and population control? Should the trend not be reversed?

It is clearly time for Indian society and the government to adopt proactive policies to promote the participation of women in the workforce.

Another Disturbing Trend: NEET is Rising

Given rapid technological developments, both mechanical and digital, and the requirement to invest more in education and training, the youth (in the age group of fifteen to twenty-four) are expected to be in educational and training institutions or joining the labour force as and when they complete their relevant education. Youth who are neither in the workforce nor in educational and training institutions are measured as Not in Employment, Education and Training (NEET). This, in a manner, measures wasting youth in a country.

ILO's Annual Report 2020 counted 1.2 billion young persons in the age group fifteen to twenty-four in 2019; 429 million (36 per cent) of them were assessed to be in employment and 509 million (42 per cent) were found to be studying in educational and training institutions. The remaining 267 million (22 per cent) were in the NEET category. This is quite a worrying proportion. More young women (31 per cent) were in NEET than men (14 per cent).

For India, based on data available for 2018, NEET was as high as 30.4 per cent, implying that three out of every ten young men from fifteen to twenty-four were not in employment, education or training. While many were probably in preparation for examinations for government service or other pursuits, many others were probably idling away or even involved in unsocial activities. This also includes a large number of young women sitting idle at home, married or unmarried. There were 24.75 crore youth in India in 2019. This meant 7.5 crore young Indians were wasting themselves in unproductive activities that year.